▶ ASSAM

A SINGHAM, BUT NOT FAIR DINKUM?

Last December, Assam **IPS officer Anand Mishra** quit service. So sure was he of getting a BJP ticket from Buxar in his home state Bihar that he drove down from Lakhimpur to Majuli to meet the visiting RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat. And this even before his resignation had been accepted. But the BJP chose Mithilesh Tiwari to replace incumbent MP and Union minister Ashwani Kumar Choubey. Seems like it's punishment for his 'Singham' vibes, which made him a social media sensation, but earned the wrath of his seniors, one of whom had pulled him up earlier for indiscipline. Especially as he would sport a camera around his shoulder and be flanked by camerapersons during public outings. Unfortunately for him, the BJP-RSS brass heed the counsel of this senior official, who was also instrumental in bringing Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma into the BJP fold. ■





▶ TAMIL NADU

That Tiruchi Thing

The major parties of Tamil Nadu—the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam—firmly believe that what is launched from Tiruchi augurs well for their election prospects. While DMK supremo **M.K. Stalin** began his campaign from Siruganur on March 22, AIADMK general secretary and former chief minister **Edappadi K. Palaniswami** flagged off his campaign from Vannankoil, also in the same district, on March 24. In this, they are following in the footsteps of their respective party stalwarts—M. Karunanidhi and M.G. Ramachandran—who, too, were strong votaries of "auspicious and successful beginnings" to triumph at the hustings in the past. Except that only one—Stalin or EPS—can be the winner. ■

▶ WEST BENGAL

THE OUTSIDERS

You may be a World Cup-winning cricketer, but when it comes to the electoral field, there's no telling where the googly might come from. Even before he could face Congress veteran Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury—unbeaten for 25 years—in Baharampore, cricketer-turned-politician **Yusuf Pathan** found himself facing the accusation of being a *bohiragawto*, an outsider. The all-rounder that he is, the 41-year-old batted the charge away by invoking none other than Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Asked by journalists how he intends to deflect the outsider charge, Pathan, who had landed in Kolkata on March 20 and proceeded to Baharampore the next day, responded: "Our prime minister Narendra Modiji is from Gujarat. Where does he contest from? It is the people's love, your ability to work, that allow you to contest from anywhere you want to in India. Also, I have come to stay here (Baharampore). This is my home." Pathan, though, is not the only *bohiragawto* in TMC. Former BJP MP and ex-cricketer Kirti Azad is TMC's candidate from Bardhaman-Durgapur, and actor Shatrughan Sinha from Asansol. The BJP has already called out the TMC for its 'hypocrisy' since the party regularly hurls the charge saffronwards, including at the prime minister. "How can the country's PM be an outsider but not TMC candidates from Gujarat and Bihar?" BJP leaders ask. ■

